

The Role of Initiation into Manhood

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Abstract:

The process of initiation, which involves change and self-discovery, has been crucial to the advancement of humanity for many years. The idea of initiation can be found in many historical contexts, such as mystery schools, secret organizations, military service, athletics, and spiritual disciplines. It is crucial to keep investigating and celebrating the various kinds of initiation that are currently available to us since they play a big role in how a person develops their identity and character.

The earliest examples of initiation can be found in ancient societies, where initiation was used to symbolize the shift from childhood to maturity. Young men were initiated into the tribe's secrets, including knowledge of farming, hunting, and other crucial abilities, during initiation rituals in various cultures. The strength and bravery of the initiates were put to the test during these rites, which frequently included painful tests and tribulations.

Initiation takes many different forms in contemporary culture, such as military service, athletic competition, and spiritual practices. Men frequently view military duty as a rite of passage since it gives them the chance to develop their discipline, teamwork, and leadership abilities. In a similar vein, sports can act as a type of initiation, instilling in young men the value of tenacity, perseverance, and a never-say-die mentality.

Numerous spiritual disciplines are utilized as means of initiation in addition to these more conventional, secular ones. To help people gain a greater comprehension of the spiritual world, several ancient mystery schools, like the Eleusinian Mysteries in ancient Greece, used initiation. Like this, many contemporary spiritual practices, such as yoga and meditation, seek to help people get a deeper awareness of who they are and their purpose in the world.

The growth of manhood is also significantly influenced by initiations into fraternal organizations like Freemasonry, and collegiate fraternities such as Skull and Bones at Yale University, and other PanHellenic fraternities. The lessons learned at initiation are frequently meant to be applied to one's daily life. These societies use ceremony and symbolism to help members gain a deeper understanding of the world and themselves. Another crucial element of the initiatory experience is the sense of belonging and community that these groups cultivate.

This article's objective is to examine the significance of the forms of manhood initiation and how it might promote personal development, self-awareness, and a better understanding of one's place in the universe.

Introduction – Why is it important?

Now that I have gone through my initiation, I am ready for anything anywhere.

- Paul's letter to the Philippians, 4:12
NET Bible®

An initiation is thought to start a fundamental transformation process inside the recipient, and its "evolution operates in both the material and the spiritual world."¹ Initiation into manhood is important for several cultural, social, and personal reasons. In many societies, it marks the transition from boyhood to adulthood and signifies the acceptance of new responsibilities and privileges. It can also serve as a rite of passage, helping young men to understand and connect with their cultural heritage and identity. Additionally, initiation rituals can provide a sense of belonging and camaraderie among men and can serve to pass on important cultural knowledge and values. On a personal level, initiation can help young men to gain self-confidence and a sense of purpose.

The process of initiation, which involves change and self-discovery, has been crucial to the advancement of humanity since time immemorable. The idea of initiation can be found in many historical contexts, such as mystery schools, secret organizations, military service, athletics, and spiritual disciplines. It is crucial to keep investigating and celebrating the various kinds of initiation that are currently available to us since they play a big role in how a person develops their identity and character. Ryan Michler opines in his podcast entitled *Initiate the Boys or They'll Burn Down the Village* that "It's extremely important that we initiate our boys into manhood. Yes, they're going to become males but that doesn't mean they're going to become men. There is a distinction. For our boys to become men, they have to be ushered and initiated into manhood."²

Malidoma Patrice Somé provides in her book *Ritual: Power, Healing and Community*:

"We need ritual because it is an expression of the fact that we recognize the difficulty of creating a different and special kind of community. A community that doesn't have a ritual cannot exist. A corporate community is not a community. It's a conglomeration of individuals in the service of an insatiable soulless entity."

"Where ritual is absent, the young ones are restless or violent, there are no real elders, and the grown-ups are bewildered. The future is dim."³

¹ Bernard, Christian. *So Mote It Be!* San Jose, CA: Supreme Grand Lodge of AMORC, 2015.
Chapter 10 - Mystical Initiation

² Michler, Ryan. "Initiate the Boys or They'll Burn the Village Down." Order of Man, April 12, 2019.
<https://www.orderofman.com/initiate-the-boys-or-theyll-burn-down-the-village/>.

³ Malidoma Patrice Somé, *Ritual: Power, Healing and Community* (Penguin Books, 1997).

According to the Art of Manliness⁴, initiations, often referred to as Rites of Passage are defined by sociologists as having three distinct components: Separation, Transition, and Re-incorporation.

Separation from the mother or parental figure is usually the first step in the process. In some cultures, this is accomplished physically, and in others it is more symbolic. In western cultures, this can take place in the form of going off to college or joining the military and having your head shaved.

This leads to the transition phase, where the boy is stripped down metaphorically, and is indoctrinated into a new way of thinking. Through interactions with others in the circle, their existing habits are one-by-one replaced with the habits of the new way of thinking. For example, in the military it is often said that to build a soldier, you must first strip them down and break old habits. "Iron sharpens iron."⁵

Once the transition has occurred, the final stage is the re-incorporation or re-integration into the new identity. The person takes on the new identity as their own, becoming one with the new paradigm. From this point forward, they associate with the new group, they engage with the new group, and they contribute to the welfare of the new group.

Historical

The earliest examples of initiation rituals can be traced back to ancient prehistoric civilizations, such as the "bison dance", depicted in cave paintings in Altamira, Spain potentially dating as far back as between 20,000 years ago⁶, where the process of initiation was used to mark the transition from childhood to adulthood. Across different cultures and societies, initiation rituals served as a rite of passage, and were used to initiate young men into the secrets, responsibilities, and roles of adulthood. The initiation process was designed to test the physical, mental, and emotional strength of the initiates, as well as to impart important skills and knowledge that were necessary for survival and the functioning of the community. The first system of spiritual teaching we are aware of is called a pattern of initiation, and it predates all organized religions. In what Karl Jaspers (1883-1969), a German-Swiss Psychiatrist and philosopher, calls "Pre-Axial Consciousness,"⁷ he postulates that the concept of pre-axial consciousness refers to the period of human history prior to the Axial Age (roughly between 800 BCE and 200 BCE) when many of the world's major religious, philosophical, and cultural traditions emerged, during which there was a more limited understanding of the individual, the community, and the cosmos. In pre-axial consciousness, human societies tended to be organized around kinship ties, with individuals seeing themselves primarily as part of a larger family or clan rather than as independent actors. People also tended

⁴ Brett & Kay McKay, *Coming of Age: The Importance of Male Rites of Passage*, Art of Manliness, November 9, 2018, Updated June 3, 2021, <https://www.artofmanliness.com/character/advice/coming-of-age-the-importance-of-male-rites-of-passage/>

⁵ "Iron Sharpens Iron": *An Exegetical Study of Proverbs 27:17*. Portland, OR: TREN, 1993.

⁶ "The Cave of Altamira." Bradshaw Foundation. Accessed February 15, 2023. <https://www.bradshawfoundation.com/spain/altamira/index.php>.

⁷ Karl Jaspers, *The Origin and Goal of History* (Zurich: Artemis, 1949), 19ff.

to view the natural world as being populated by a variety of spirits and gods, and the cosmos as being fundamentally unpredictable and mysterious.

In many cultures, initiation rituals were accompanied by physical trials and ordeals, such as fasting, facing wild animals, and undergoing painful tattooing or scarification⁸. For example, in ancient societies such as the Native Americans, young men were initiated into manhood through ceremonies that included physical challenges such as hunting and tracking, as well as spiritual practices and teachings.⁹ Similarly, in many African tribes, boys were taken away from their families and communities to live with the men, where they were taught hunting, warfare, and other important skills, and had to undergo various rituals and ordeals.¹⁰ These ceremonies were not only about physical strength, but also about mental and emotional fortitude, and were a way for the society to ensure that only the strongest and most capable men were able to take on the responsibilities of adulthood and protect the community.

In ancient Greece and Rome, young men were initiated into the military through rigorous physical and mental training and were expected to prove their courage in battle.¹¹ These military initiations were not only about physical strength but also about mental and emotional fortitude, it was a way for the society to ensure that only the strongest and most capable men were able to take on the responsibilities of adulthood and protect the community. Furthermore, these rituals also served a spiritual purpose, providing the initiates with a deeper understanding of their place in the world and the connection to the spiritual realm.¹²

In addition to these physical and martial initiations, many ancient cultures also had spiritual initiations, which were designed to provide the initiates with a deeper understanding of the spiritual realm and their place in the world. In many cultures, the initiates would be taught the stories, myths, and legends of their people, which were believed to hold important spiritual truths and teachings. The spiritual initiations were often accompanied by rituals and ceremonies, such as fasting, meditation, and visions quests, that aimed to prepare the initiate for a deeper understanding of the spiritual realm.

The concept of initiation in ancient civilizations was an important rite of passage into manhood, and it was a crucial step in the development of a young man's character and identity. The experience of initiation helped to shape the individual's sense of self and their understanding of the world around them. Even though these rituals and practices are not as common in contemporary societies, the concept of initiation remains an important part of human development and continues to play a vital role in the lives of many individuals today. The initiatory practices in ancient

⁸ "Inscribing the Body". Schildkrout, Enid (2004-06-11). Annual Review of Anthropology. 33: 320

⁹ "Rites Of Passage: North American Indian Rites." Encyclopedia of Religion. Encyclopedia.com.
<https://www.encyclopedia.com/environment/encyclopedias-almanacs-transcripts-and-maps/rites-passage-north-american-indian-rites>.

¹⁰ Gilbert Herdt, *Secrecy and Cultural Reality: Utopian Ideologies of the Ne Guinea Men's House* (University of Michigan, 2003).

¹¹ Bremmer, Jan N. *Becoming a Man in Ancient Greece and Rome: Essays on Myths and Rituals of Initiation*. Tübingen: Mohr Siebeck, 2021.

¹² Jan N. Bremmer, *Becoming a Man in Ancient Greece and Rome: Essays on Myths and Rituals of Initiation*, (Groningen: Mohr Siebeck, 2021).

civilizations are still being practiced in different cultures and societies in a modified form and it continues to be an important aspect of personal growth and self-discovery.

Military, Athletics, et al.

In modern times, initiation can be found in a variety of forms, including military service and athletics. These forms of initiation provide individuals with the opportunity to learn discipline, teamwork, and leadership skills, and to gain a deeper understanding of the self and one's place in the world.

Military service, for example, is often seen as a rite of passage for men, providing them with the opportunity to learn discipline, teamwork, and leadership skills. The physical and mental challenges that are faced during military training, as well as the camaraderie that is formed among soldiers, can lead to a sense of personal growth and self-discovery. Initiation rituals in the military are considered important tools to aid in the socialization of new recruits. These members are stripped of their precious identity and re-built in the image of a soldier, marine, airman, seaman, guardian, or others. This is done for survival and unit cohesion. In the military, there needs to be a degree of group think, where every person is required to be “on the same page” so that the tactical environment is not compromised. This has led to some who feel this is not necessarily a good thing. There exists a potential for abuse in the initiatic experience, such as hazing, which can lead to a breakdown in social cohesion and toxic practices, which will be discussed in a later section.

Comparably, athletics and sport completions can also serve as a form of initiation, teaching men the importance of hard work, perseverance, and a “never-give-up” attitude. The physical and mental challenges that are faced during training and competition, as well as the camaraderie that is formed among teammates, can lead to a sense of personal growth and self-discovery. While there is a push for more equality in sports today, there is still a need to physically separate the boys and girls, as physical body structure can play a difference in the sport and the chance of injury. Boys and men's sports have over time evolved to be more contact driven. American Football for example is played using extraordinary amounts of protective gear, but due to the speed and violence of the collisions, even the best protective gear cannot guarantee protection. Because of this, or maybe as a result of this (post hoc, ergo propter hoc – after this, therefore because of this), players have gotten bigger and faster, and the collisions have gotten more violent. Despite all of this, sports have always served as a foster for team and selflessness. It is analogous to the military in the ways it supports initiation, from breaking down, to building back up.

Sports have always served as a form of initiation for young men, with games such as *Ulama* created by the Mayans in Central America, *Pato* – the official sport of Argentina – which was originally played with a live duck instead of a ball (a sort of hybrid between polo and basketball), and *Pankration* – an early form of mixed martial arts from ancient Greece.¹³ In modern days, sports such as football, soccer, basketball, et al., have provided the platform for the experience, but

¹³ List25. “12 Crazy Sports from the Ancient World.” Today I Found Out, May 28, 2013.
<https://www.todayifoundout.com/index.php/2013/05/12-crazy-sports-from-the-ancient-world/>.

regardless of the sport, the initiation is the inculcation of the ethos with the sport. The sport itself becomes somewhat irrelevant. While there is a cultural difference in the various sports (football player and soccer players don't necessarily fold in together) it is the collective experience each person takes from the team that provides the initiation.

It's worth noting that initiation in modern times is not limited to a specific group or society, it can be found in various forms, and it can be a personal journey of self-discovery, growth and understanding. Many people today actively seek out initiation through different activities and practices, whether it's joining a military service, participating in sports, or engaging in spiritual practices. The concept of initiation remains an important aspect of human development and continues to play a vital role in the lives of many individuals today.

Spiritual

In addition to the more secular forms of initiation such as military service and sports, there are also many spiritual disciplines that are used as a form of initiation. These spiritual practices and disciplines are designed to provide individuals with a deeper understanding of the self and one's place in the world, and to foster personal growth and self-discovery.

One example of early spiritual initiation can be found in the ancient mystery schools that existed in ancient Greece, Egypt, and Rome, which used initiation to provide individuals with a deeper understanding of the spiritual realm. These mystery schools, such as the Eleusinian, Dionysian, Hermetic, Orphic, and Pythagoras Mystery Schools, were secret societies that were based on religious and philosophical teachings, and they were only open to a select group of initiated members.¹⁴ The initiates were exposed to a variety of spiritual practices and teachings, such as meditation, ritual, and symbolism, which were intended to help them gain a deeper understanding of the spiritual realm and their place in the world. By this wide-ranging topic, and while only touch on here, their initiation could be explored in detail on an individual basis.

Similarly, many modern spiritual disciplines, such as meditation and yoga, also aim to provide individuals with a deeper understanding of the self and one's place in the world. These practices are often used to gain a deeper understanding of the mind and body, and to develop a greater sense of inner peace and well-being. Meditative practices such as Chakra Dhyana, Mantras, Third Eye (Ajna Chakra), Trataka ("Still Gazing"), Tantra, et al.,¹⁵ provide a unique opportunity to explore oneself. They are usually experienced over time and with a teacher or yogi who imparts the knowledge as the form or initiation.

Additionally, some spiritual traditions and practices, such as shamanic and indigenous practices, such as those of the aboriginal native Americans also include initiation rituals that are intended to

¹⁴ "The Mystery Schools" Gale Encyclopedia of the Unusual and Unexplained. . Encyclopedia.com. 17 Jan. 2023 ." Encyclopedia.com. Encyclopedia.com, January 26, 2023.

<https://www.encyclopedia.com/science/encyclopedias-almanacs-transcripts-and-maps/mystery-schools>.

¹⁵ Harrison, Paul. "12 Yogic Meditation Techniques Everyone Needs to Know." The Daily Meditation coaching sessions, December 14, 2022. <https://www.thedailymeditation.com/yoga-meditation-techniques-2>.

provide individuals with a deeper understanding of the spiritual realm and their place in the world. Kathy Weiser writes in her blog post entitled *Native American Rituals and Ceremonies*:

“Often referred to as “religion,” most Native Americans did not consider their spirituality, ceremonies, and rituals as “religion,” in the way that Christians do. Rather, their beliefs and practices form an integral and seamless part of their very being. Like other aboriginal peoples around the world, their beliefs were heavily influenced by their methods of acquiring food, – from hunting to agriculture. They also embraced ceremonies and rituals that provided power to conquer the difficulties of life, as well as events and milestones, such as puberty, marriage, and death. Over the years, practices and ceremonies changed with tribes’ needs.”¹⁶

In her article, she goes on to describe one of the most influential and well know rite of passage for young men – the Vision Quest. This can take many forms, but most suffer the same purpose – to act as a guide in helping determine the path to take in the future. The nature and intensity of the ritual would vary depending on the tribe. These sorts of rituals are still preformed today in varying different ways.

One of the most relevant spiritual commencements in modern cultures is the initiation rituals within the various organized religions of the day. Christian initiation rituals include baptism, confirmation, and the Eucharist.¹⁷ In baptism, a person is symbolically cleansed of sin and becomes a member of the Christian community. Confirmation is a rite in which a person affirms their faith and is "sealed" with the Holy Spirit. The Eucharist, also known as Holy Communion or the Lord's Supper, is a sacrament in which bread and wine are consecrated and consumed as a symbol of Jesus' body and blood.

Jewish initiation rituals include circumcision (Brit Milah or Bris)¹⁸ for boys at age 8 days, and a ceremony called a bar mitzvah¹⁹ for boys when they turn 13 years old, which marks the point at which a young boy is considered responsible for their own actions in Jewish law. During the Bar Mitzvah ceremony, the boy reads from the Torah and leads the congregation in prayer. This is a public declaration of the boy's commitment to his faith and his acceptance of the responsibilities of being a Jewish adult. The Bar Mitzvah celebration often includes a festive meal and other customs, such as the boy being hoisted up in a chair and the traditional dance known as the *Hora*.

Islamic initiation rituals include the declaration of faith (Shahada or Shahadah), which is the first of the Five Pillars of Islam, and the pilgrimage to Mecca (hajj), which is one of the Five Pillars of Islam and is required of all Muslims who are able to make the journey.²⁰ According to Dr. Ibrahim

¹⁶ Weiser, Kathy. “Native American Rituals and Ceremonies.” *Legends of America*, February 2020.
<https://www.legendsofamerica.com/na-ceremonies/>.

¹⁷ “Introduction to the Seven Sacraments.” St. Anthony (revere), 2023.
<https://www.stanthonyssrevere.org/introduction-seven-sacraments>.

¹⁸ My Jewish Learning. “The Brit Milah (BRIS): What You Need to Know.” My Jewish Learning, May 6, 2022.
<https://www.myjewishlearning.com/article/the-brit-milah-bris-ceremony/>.

¹⁹ “Bar Mitzvah - Entering Adulthood - Chabad.org.” Accessed January 26, 2023.
https://www.chabad.org/library/article_cdo/aid/144321/jewish/Bar-Mitzvah.htm.

²⁰ “Islamic Rites of Passage.” Accessed January 26, 2023. <https://www.finalsite.com/resources>.

Aldasoqi with the University of Memphis' Kemmons Wilson School of Hospitality²¹, the Shahada is typically recited during the "Aqiqah" ceremony, which marks a Muslim boy's transition into manhood. A Muslim boy's head is shaved during the Aqiqah rite, and he is also given a name, frequently one that honors a prophet or other holy person. Additionally, he has been circumcised, which is seen as a significant rite of passage for Muslim males. As a sign of the boy's dedication to Islam and his acceptance of the obligations that come with being a Muslim man, the Shahada is frequently recited during the Aqiqah ceremony. The Aqiqah ceremony is an important event in the life of a Muslim boy and is seen as a way of introducing him to the Islamic community and reinforcing his connection to his faith. It is a time when family and friends come together to celebrate and offer support to the young man as he takes his first steps into adulthood.

It's worth noting that initiation in spiritual practices and disciplines is not limited to any specific tradition, it can be found in various forms and practices, such as meditation, yoga, martial arts, and even some forms of therapy. These practices and disciplines can be used as a form of initiation to provide individuals with a deeper understanding of the self and one's place in the world, and to foster personal growth and self-discovery. Additionally, some people may seek initiation through a personal journey of self-discovery, in which they explore different spiritual practices and disciplines and find what resonates with them.

Fraternal

In modern times, initiations into secret organizations like Freemasonry also fulfill this purpose. The local stonemason fraternities, which began to govern the requirements for stonemasons and how they interacted with clients and authorities around the end of the fourteenth century, are where the fraternal organization of freemasonry had its start. However, ritual and initiation have a long history in Freemasonry and play a significant role in the culture of the group. These ceremonies and initiations are designed to encourage personal development and self-discovery while giving males (mostly, with a few exceptions) a greater knowledge of the organization and its guiding ideals. The three levels of the medieval trade guilds—Apprentice, Journeyman or Fellow (today termed Fellowcraft), and Master Mason—remain in the degrees of Freemasonry. These are the degrees offered by Craft (or Blue Lodge) Freemasonry. These are part of the "York Rite", or American Rite and the "Ancient Rite", or the "Scottish Rite" of Freemasonry, depending on jurisdiction.²²

Freemasonry employs a series of ritual dramas based on the metaphor of the construction of King Solomon's Temple to impart moral lessons. These plays, which are presented as part of the initiation process, employ symbolism, metaphor, and ritual to impart moral teachings and promote personal development. The new members, referred to as "Brothers", "Masons" or "Freemasons," or collectively as the "Craft" are required to uphold a set of moral standards and work toward

²¹ Dr. Ibrahim Aldasoqi in discussion with the author, January, 2023.

²² Hodapp, Christopher. "Those Notorious First Three Scottish Rite Degrees." Web log. *Freemasons for Dummies* (blog), May 27, 2017. <https://freemasonsfordummies.blogspot.com/2017/05/those-notorious-first-three-scottish.html>.

improving themselves. Brotherhood and generosity are also highly valued in Freemasonry, and many Freemason lodges participate in volunteer work and philanthropic endeavors.

In that both include a process of personal development, the initiation experience in Freemasonry can be compared to the change from boy to man. As they go through the degrees in Freemasonry, initiates are metaphorically "born again," expected to take on more responsibility and work toward improving themselves and contributing to the greater good of the Craft and to the broader community at large. Like this, growing from a boy to a man is considered in many cultures as a period of personal development during which young men are expected to assume more responsibility and establish their independence. Additionally, a rite of passage—a ceremonial occasion that denotes a significant change or stage of life²³—is present in both the Freemasonry initiation experience and the development from boy to man. In both cases, the initiate is introduced to new ideas, values, and responsibilities that are expected of them as an adult.

As young men grow from being boys to being men, moral ideals, honesty, and fraternity are crucial virtues to impart in them. Freemasonry places a strong emphasis on these concepts. It's crucial to remember that depending on the culture and situation, the precise parallels, and distinctions between the two will change. Noting that Freemasonry has a spiritual component and that its members are supposed to believe in a Supreme Being, it is equally important to note that it is not a religion.

Initiation is used by other secret societies, such as college fraternities, to symbolize the passage from childhood to adulthood. The Skull and Bones society, a covert organization at Yale University, is an illustration of such a fraternity. The influential alumni of this organization, which includes former US President George H.W. Bush and his son George W. Bush, are noted for their secrecy.²⁴ Similar to this, Panhellenic college fraternities, which are prevalent at several schools and institutions across the United States, employ initiation to unite members and instruct them on the organization's ideals and ideas.

Other concealed organizations that date back to the late 19th and early 20th centuries include the Theosophical Society²⁵, the Ordo Templi Orientis²⁶, and the Hermetic Order of the Golden Dawn²⁷. These organizations have initiations that are designed to give people a greater awareness of the spiritual realm and their purpose in the universe. These societies are founded on various spiritual and philosophical beliefs and practices.

It is worth noting that initiations in secret organizations, such as Freemasonry and college fraternities, are sometimes cloaked in secrecy and that the rites and procedures are not accessible

²³ "Rite of Passage Definition & Meaning." Rite of Passage. Merriam-Webster. Accessed February 5, 2023. <https://www.merriam-webster.com/dictionary/rite%20of%20passage>.

²⁴ "Skull and Bones." Encyclopædia Britannica. Encyclopædia Britannica, inc., December 9, 2022. <https://www.britannica.com/topic/Skull-and-Bones-Yale>.

²⁵ "Home Page." Theosophical Society in America. Accessed January 26, 2023. <https://www.theosophical.org/>.

²⁶ Admin. US Grand Lodge OTO. US Grand Lodge, January 11, 2023. <https://oto-usa.org/>.

²⁷ "The Hermetic Order of the Golden Dawn®." The Hermetic Order of The Golden Dawn®. Accessed January 26, 2023. <https://hermeticgoldendawn.org/>.

to the public at large. The purpose of these initiations is to foster a sense of exclusivity and belonging among members as well as a sense of solidarity and friendship (or Brotherhood).²⁸ These initiations have drawn criticism for being risky and perhaps damaging, primarily due to the hidden nature of the ritual and is often due to a lack of knowledge or intentional misleading or defamatory information, but has non-the-less spurned such actions in the past as an Anti-Masonic political party.²⁹

Initiations in secret societies, like Freemasonry, college fraternities and other civic fraternal organizations, serve as a form of commencement in modern times. These initiations are intended to provide individuals with a deeper understanding of the organization and its values and principles, and to foster personal growth and self-discovery. However, it's important to ensure that any initiation practices are safe and respectful for all participants and that secrecy should not be used to cover up harmful or dangerous practices.

Potential for Negative Outcomes

There can be some negatives to initiation rites, particularly if the initiations are not conducted in a safe and respectful manner. Some initiation practices, such as hazing, can be dangerous and potentially harmful, both physically and emotionally. Hazing rituals can include activities such as excessive alcohol consumption, sleep deprivation, and physical abuse, which can lead to serious injury or even death. In addition, hazing can create a culture of fear and intimidation, and can lead to feelings of isolation and alienation among initiates.³⁰

A good example of this is the Tailhook scandal, where sexual harassment and assault on women were perpetrated on September 5-7, 1991 at the U.S. Navy's Tailhook Symposium in Las Vegas, Nevada by U.S. Navy and Marine Corps officers and military contractors, where a female Navy Lieutenant was forced to "run the gauntlet" while being groped and accosted.³¹ While these sort of abuses are rare, when they occur, they are often so egregious that they shine a very bright spotlight on the negative aspects of initiation rituals in the military.

Another negative aspect of initiation rites is that they can perpetuate harmful stereotypes and discrimination. For example, initiations that are based on gender or race can reinforce harmful stereotypes and discrimination and can create an atmosphere of division and mistrust among members. Moreover, some initiations can also be used as a tool of manipulation and control, particularly in secret societies or organizations with a hierarchical structure. Such initiations can

²⁸ "Secret Society." Secret Society. Encyclopædia Britannica, inc. Accessed February 1, 2023.
<https://www.britannica.com/topic/secret-society>.

²⁹ Garlinghouse, Tom, and Callum McKelvie. "Freemasons: History, Facts and Myths." LiveScience. Purch, January 21, 2022. <https://www.livescience.com/freemasons.html>.

³⁰ "Examples of Hazing." Office of Victim Assistance, September 14, 2018.
<https://www.colorado.edu/ova/examples-hazing>.

³¹ Britannica, The Editors of Encyclopaedia. "Tailhook scandal". Encyclopedia Britannica, 29 Aug. 2022, <https://www.britannica.com/event/Tailhook-scandal>. Accessed 26 January 2023.

be used as a way to manipulate and control members, and to maintain the power of the organization's leaders.

It's worth noting that the negative impacts of initiation rites can be mitigated by ensuring that initiations are conducted in a safe and respectful manner, and by promoting inclusivity and diversity among members. It's important to ensure that initiation practices align with the organization's values and principles, and that they do not perpetuate harmful stereotypes or discrimination.

Conclusion

In conclusion, initiation is a complex process that has played a crucial role in human development for centuries. It is found in various forms throughout history, including ancient and modern mystery schools, secret societies, military service, sports, and spiritual disciplines. These forms of initiation provide individuals with the opportunity to learn discipline, teamwork, and leadership skills, and to gain a deeper understanding of the self and one's place in the world. Initiations in manhood play a significant role in the development of an individual's character and identity.

However, it's important to note that there are also negative aspects to initiation rites. Some initiation practices, such as hazing, can be dangerous and potentially harmful, both physically and emotionally. Hazing rituals can include activities such as excessive alcohol consumption, sleep deprivation, and physical abuse, which can lead to serious injury or even death. In addition, hazing can create a culture of fear and intimidation, and can lead to feelings of isolation and alienation among initiates. Other negative aspects of initiation rites include perpetuation of harmful stereotypes and discrimination, and the use of initiation as a tool of manipulation and control.

Despite these negatives, it's important to continue to explore and celebrate the many forms of initiation that are available to us today. By ensuring that initiations are conducted in a safe and respectful manner, and by promoting inclusivity and diversity among members, we can continue to benefit from the positive aspects of initiation while minimizing the negative impacts.